Diversity Statement

Chris Cho

Department of Philosophy, Syracuse University

Non-inclusive philosophy does a disservice to philosophy. Philosophy advances, and has advanced, by questioning assumptions, considering unfamiliar perspectives, and subjecting our ideas to challenges from people who do not necessarily share our backgrounds or starting points. A philosophical community that excludes or discourages some of its members, I believe, loses not only those members' voices but also opportunities for better philosophical inquiry. Hence I am deeply committed to diversity and inclusion, a commitment that grows out of my own experience as an international student.

I have been an international student pretty much all my life. I was born in South Korea and moved to Vancouver when I was about eleven years old. When I arrived, I spoke virtually no English, and there were only a handful of Asian students at my elementary school. Yet my teachers and classmates made me feel that I belonged. Four years later, I returned to Korea to attend an international school, where my classmates came from all over the world. I had friends from the U.S., India, Japan, and China, to name a few. I subsequently attended the University of Toronto, where I again studied in an extraordinarily diverse community. Moving among these educational environments taught me that diversity and inclusion is not simply a matter of bringing people with different backgrounds into the same room. It requires fostering an environment in which those differences can become sources of engagement rather than barriers to participation.

This informs both what I teach and how I teach it. In designing courses, I aim to expose students to philosophers with a range of backgrounds, identities, and perspectives. I want my students to see people like themselves in philosophy. I remember learning about Jaegwon Kim as an undergraduate and immediately feeling a connection when I learned about his Korean background. Learning about someone with whom I shared a cultural background represented in the discipline made philosophy feel more accessible to me and deepened my engagement with it. (Indeed, there was a part of me that believed if I pursued philosophy, I would eventually get a chance to meet him—though, unfortunately, that never came to be.) And I have seen similar reactions with my students. For example, when teaching abortion, I have found women students especially engaged by the work of Judith Jarvis Thomson and Mary Anne Warren, and I believe this is largely because they, in a way, feel connected to these philosophers and their work—just like how I felt connected to Jaegwon Kim. I want students from a wide range of backgrounds to be able to encounter philosophy as a discipline in which people like them can participate and make important contributions.

Diversity in the classroom, however, matters not only in whose works appear on the syllabus, but also, I believe, in whose voices shape the discussion. Having been an international undergraduate student myself, I understand that students may be reluctant to speak in front of an entire class for various reasons, say, cultural expectations, uncertainty about their command of English, previous experiences of exclusion, or simply a quiet disposition. I therefore regularly employ small group discussions and other lower-pressure opportunities for participation before bringing ideas into a whole class discussion. I also take students' questions and comments seriously, even

if their views may be controversial. Fortunately, my efforts have not have gone unnoticed. As one student wrote in their evaluation, my course "made me think about others' opinions more than my own." Another remarked that "the way Chris allowed for group discussions fostered an amazing environment where everyone had fun discussing topics and our own views without any judgement." An inclusive classroom should not require students to already know or have the "right" thing to say before they are permitted to participate. And I believe my role is to help students articulate their views carefully, examine their assumptions, and engage respectfully with disagreement.

My commitment to inclusion extends beyond my own classroom. From 2023 to 2025, I served as a Graduate Teaching Mentor at Syracuse University, which includes leading small group sessions with international graduate students during the annual TA Orientation. I worked with graduate students from various countries, including Bangladesh, China, India, Nigeria, Pakistan, and Russia, as they prepared to teach in U.S. classrooms. These conversations made especially vivid how much classroom norms can vary across cultural contexts. In some contexts, for example, students are discouraged from speaking unless they are confident their responses are clearly formulated or correct. A student accustomed to such norms may appear disengaged in a U.S. classroom, when, in fact, they are approaching participation differently and, by their standards, respectfully. Discussing these differences with international graduate students has made me more attentive to the assumptions built into familiar teaching practices and more deliberate about creating multiple avenues for students to participate and succeed.

I have also contributed to inclusive efforts in philosophy through my involvement with the Minorities and Philosophy (MAP) chapter at Syracuse University. With the aim of increasing awareness for diversity and inclusion, together with my co-organizer (Steven Alvarez), I organized a department talk, "Gaslighting in Axiology," given by Cameron Kirk-Giannini (Rutgers). I am still an active participant for MAP, thinking about how we can further increase awareness of diversity and inclusion in philosophy and philosophical work on diversity in general.

Philosophy, I believe, is at its best when people with different experiences and perspectives challenge one another's assumptions, offer arguments that may otherwise be overlooked, and participate as genuine members of a shared intellectual community. As a faculty member, I would continue working toward that goal through inclusive course design, attentive teaching and mentoring, and service that expands participation in philosophy.